

Cyberbullying

Digital communication and online profiles are easy and fast ways to share information with lots of people, but they can also be used to upset and hurt people.

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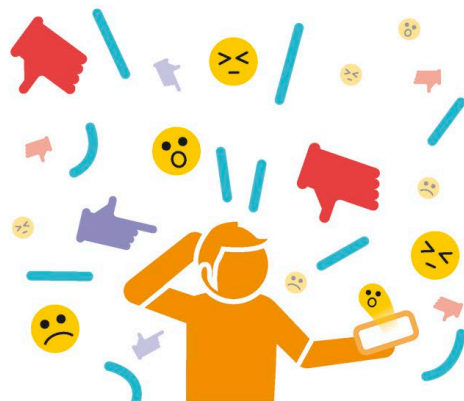
What is cyberbullying?

Threatening or embarrassing someone through technology is a type of bullying. With many people carrying electronic devices 24/7, cyberbullying can occur at any time of day, no matter where the bully or bullied person is—making it very difficult for a person to avoid once they've been targeted.

Due to the ease with which information can be shared on the Internet, some types of cyberbullying can quickly reach a very wide audience, exacerbating the hurt and humiliation of victims. And, once something has been posted online, removing it completely can sometimes be impossible, causing harm to the bullied person long after the actual act first happened.

▷ Electronic intimidation

With the tap of a finger, personal, embarrassing, or cruel messages can be shared with the world, making cyberbullying both hurtful and dangerous.



Types of cyberbullying

Cyberbullying is invasive, cruel, and difficult to deal with. As cyberbullies often remain anonymous, tracing the source and stopping the cyberbullying can sometimes be extremely difficult. There are many types of cyberbullying, all of which can be carried out via email, text messages, or social media.

Hurtful, intimidating, and threatening messages may be sent.

Unwanted attention can turn into sexual harassment or stalking.

Embarrassing photos or hurtful posts could be posted or shared to humiliate a person.

Identity theft of a social media profile can occur if someone hacks into another person's online accounts.

A person can be impersonated through the use of fake profiles.

Personal or defamatory information about another person can be posted or shared.

PARENT TIPS

Signs of cyberbullying

Many of the signs are similar to those of regular bullying, but may be intensified by electronic devices.

- The way a teen uses their devices might change, such as suddenly not using them, being secretive when using them, or being online obsessively.
- A teen's behavior might change. They might become sad or withdrawn, lash out, or be reluctant to do things they usually enjoy.
- There may be unexplained physical symptoms, such as headaches, upset stomach, or decreased appetite.
- They refuse to talk about what they're doing online or who they're talking to.